

TOPIC 6: SOCIAL CONFLICT

1. Meaning of Social Conflict

Social conflict is a disagreement, struggle or clash between individuals, groups or communities over interests, values, resources, power or ideas. It occurs when people or groups have opposing goals or when one party feels that its rights or interests are being threatened by another.

Conflict is a normal part of human interaction, but it becomes dangerous when it turns violent or is not properly managed.

2. Causes of Social Conflict

- **Competition for Scarce Resources** – land, water, jobs, political power.
- **Differences in Values and Beliefs** – religious, ethnic or cultural differences.
- **Poor Communication** – misunderstanding and lack of dialogue.
- **Injustice and Inequality** – discrimination, marginalisation or unfair treatment.
- **Poverty and Unemployment** – frustration that can lead to violence.
- **Political Ambition and Power Struggle.**
- **Ethnic and Religious Intolerance.**
- **Breakdown of Traditional Authority and Family Values.**
- **Rumour, Hate Speech and Social Media Misinformation.**

3. Effects of Conflict on Individuals and Society

On Individuals:

- Physical injury, death or trauma.
- Loss of property and livelihood.
- Fear, anxiety and psychological stress.
- Displacement and separation of families.

On Society:

- Breakdown of law and order.
- Destruction of infrastructure (schools, markets, roads).
- Hindrance to economic development and investment.
- Disunity and distrust among groups.
- Increase in crime, refugee problems and poverty.
- Loss of human lives and human resources.

4. Ways of Resolving Conflicts

- **Dialogue and Negotiation** – talking to understand each other's views and reach a compromise.
- **Mediation** – involving a neutral third party to help the conflicting parties reach agreement.
- **Arbitration** – a neutral person listens and makes a binding decision.
- **Reconciliation** – restoring friendship and trust after the conflict.
- **Court Action / Legal Process** – using the judicial system when necessary.
- **Traditional Methods** – involving elders, traditional rulers or community leaders.
- **Apology and Forgiveness** – saying sorry and accepting the apology.

5. Importance of Tolerance and Forgiveness

Tolerance means accepting and respecting people who are different from us in opinion, religion, culture or ethnic group. Forgiveness means letting go of anger and the desire for revenge after being wronged.

Importance:

- They prevent small disagreements from becoming big conflicts.
- They promote peaceful coexistence in a multi-ethnic and multi-religious society like Nigeria.
- They heal relationships and build trust.
- They reduce the cycle of violence and revenge.
- They create an atmosphere where development and progress can take place.

6. Summary

Social conflict arises from competing interests, differences and injustice. It harms individuals and society. Through dialogue, mediation, tolerance and forgiveness, conflicts can be resolved peacefully. Every citizen has a role to play in preventing and resolving conflicts.

End of Topic 6 – Social Conflict